



A Media Organisation Keeps Its Data Safe With PostgreSQL

Bineeta Guharoy, one of the EnterpriseDB PostgreSQL contest winners, shares her views on why she trusts PostgreSQL to keep critical data safe.

A media house is well aware of the importance of keeping its content in safe hands at all times, and away from hackers. Bineeta Guharoy is a senior Web developer at a national news and media organisation, and believes in the power of open source. She shares with *LINUX For You* how she uses open source solutions to ensure the safety of the firm's content.

The first stint with open source

Guharoy got acquainted with UNIX when she did a short course on programming in the early 2000s. She started exploring Linux in 2003, but got discouraged, as people assumed open source solutions were not secure. At that point in time, she worked with BSM Networks. Guharoy proved the rumours wrong by using MySQL and PHP. She claims, "People generally feel that the Windows environment is more secure, but the fact is that Windows machines hang faster, and are prone to more virus attacks. People can easily hack files and install EXE files when you use Windows. On the other hand, there are many security-related features in Linux that make it difficult to hack or install files."

She joined her current employer, the media house, in 2008 and was pleased to find that open source was already a part of the organisation. However, she was not very pleased in the beginning, as the team was not using MySQL, which Guharoy was comfortable with. "The media house has seven Web portals and all these websites are maintained on one database on PostgreSQL," Guharoy explains. PostgreSQL is used for the CMS, website database maintenance and back-end functions. "It doesn't matter what is used in

the front end—we can develop applications in PHP, C or Java. One of the best parts about open source is that there are no costs involved. We did not require major hardware, and continued to use our simple servers. At present, the organisation uses IBM System X3620M3 for database management, which is a very efficient and high-capacity storage system," Guharoy comments. "There are so many features in PostgreSQL that we have not implemented as yet. Right now, I am still learning the features that it offers by reading up information online. When we face a problem, we look for a solution and apply it. This method has been working for us so far. For instance, with two to three lakh visitors to the websites, there are too many database connections, which creates a problem. There are many variables that can be configured and tuned for smooth viewing. In our case, we tuned the RAM," she affirms.

A secure database solution

Guharoy's profile is related to security and firewalls, and after her encounter with PostgreSQL, she has discovered that it is more secure than MySQL and proprietary solutions. It took her a while to get acquainted with PostgreSQL, as it is a vast subject, but Guharoy finds that the security offered by it is on par with that of an Oracle environment. "Keeping the data content of websites safe, and making it available to viewers 24/7 is mission-critical to the organisation. With PostgreSQL, it is difficult for outsiders to find out where the database is stored. For instance, if I create a database in MySQL, the default directory of installation is `/var/lib/mysql`. It shows the database directory, with names and categories, and hackers can easily rip the database, tar and download it. However, in PostgreSQL, the directory names are